

STEALING TIME

What makes Rickey Henderson run?

By David Grann, *New Yorker*, September 12, 2005

One summer night not long ago, Rickey Henderson, the greatest base stealer and lead-off hitter in baseball history, stood in a dugout, pinching the front of his jersey and plucking it several inches from his chest—"peacocking," as some players call it. He went through the same pregame rituals that he has performed since he was a rookie outfielder with the Oakland A's, in 1979. He sorted through a bunch of bats, asking, "Which one of you bad motherfuckers has got a hit in you?" Picking one up with resin on the handle, he cocked it back, waiting for an imaginary pitch, and talked to himself in the third person, the words running together so fast that they were nearly unintelligible: "Let's-burn-Rickey-come-on-let's-burn."

Henderson is accustomed not only to beating his opponents but also to lording his abilities over them. As a ten-time All Star for the A's, the New York Yankees, and seven other teams, he stole more than fourteen hundred bases—a record that is considered untouchable, like Joe DiMaggio's fifty-six-game hitting streak. He scored more runs than Ty Cobb, Babe Ruth, or Hank Aaron. Bill James, the oracle of baseball statistics, wrote, "Without exaggerating one inch, you could find fifty Hall of Famers who, all taken together, don't own as many records." Or, as Henderson puts it, "I'm a walking record."

As Henderson stepped onto the field, he stopped abruptly. A foul odor was seeping from under the dugout. "Where's it coming from?" one of his teammates asked. Several players bent down, trying to find the source of the smell; previously, the manager had found a dead rat in the stadium. "I think it's coming from over here," one player said. "See that hole?" Henderson tried to ignore the commotion and resume his routine. He walked toward the batter's box, moving casually, as if he were out for an evening stroll. An opposing player once noted that it took him longer to get to the batter's box than to drive to the stadium. Henderson has said that his slow approach is a way to get into a pitcher's head; opponents have said that it is simply another means for Henderson to let the world take stock of him. As he reached the batter's box, informing the world what Rickey was going to do to the ball, he again seemed disconcerted, and looked up at the crowd: there were only six hundred or so fans in the stadium, and many of the women had dressed up, as part of a promotional Eighties Night, in sequins and lace stockings, like Madonna in her "Like a Virgin" phase. Earlier, Henderson had confessed to me, "Last night, I dropped down on my knees and I asked God, 'Why are you doing this to Rickey? Why did you put me here?'"

An announcer called his name on the scratchy P.A. System: "Now batting lead-off for the San Diego Surf Dawgs. . .RICKEY HENDERSON." The man who once proclaimed "I am the greatest of all time!" was, at the age of forty-six, playing in the Golden Baseball League. It wasn't the majors. It wasn't even part of the minor-league farm system. It was an independent league, which consisted largely of players who had never made it to the minors, or had washed out of them. Created by two Stanford business-school graduates, the league—which began operating this spring, with eight teams in Arizona and California—is widely considered to be the bottom of the bottom. Yet it is here that Henderson suited up for three thousand dollars a month, less than he could bring in selling a piece of memorabilia from his days in the majors.

"Come on, hot dawwwg, let's see what you can do!" a fan yelled.

Henderson tapped the dirt out of his cleats and got into his crouch, staring at the pitcher, a twenty-four-year-old right-hander for the Mesa Miners. Several nights earlier, Henderson had singled and stolen second base, sliding head first in a cloud of dust, to the delight of fans, but, this time, he hit a weak liner to the second baseman for an easy out. As he made his way to the dugout, one of the hecklers in the crowd yelled, "Hey, Rickey, where's your fucking wheelchair?"

Other baseball greats have insisted on playing past their prime: at forty, Babe Ruth, in his last major-league season, batted .181 for the Boston Braves. But Henderson's decision to go so far as to join the Surf Dawgs—which, the team's former publicist admitted, was frequently assumed to be a girls' softball team—has been a source of astonishment. His last stint in the majors was in 2003, when he played part of the season for the Los Angeles Dodgers. He hit a mere .208, with three stolen bases. (His last productive season was in 1999.) The Dodgers management, concluding that time had finally defeated "the man of steal," as he was often called, unceremoniously released him. He had played three thousand and eighty-one games, putting him fourth on the all-time list. He was forty-four years old, and most fans reasonably assumed that he would retire and wait for his induction into the Hall of Fame. Instead, he played the 2004 season with the Newark Bears, in the independent Atlantic League, before switching to the Golden Baseball League. Manny Ramirez, the Boston Red Sox slugger, who played alongside

Henderson in 2002, has said that Henderson must be “crazy,” and a sportswriter declared that it would take “a team of psychiatrists” to figure him out. Even one of his three daughters, Alexis, asked, “Dad, why are you doing this?”

A few hours before the game against the Miners, I found Henderson sitting on a metal chair in the Surf Dawgs’ locker room, with his shirt off. He insisted that he was no different from anyone else in the league: he simply wanted to make it to the majors. But he also seemed shocked by his own predicament, by the riddle of age. As he put it, “There are pieces of this puzzle that Rickey is still working out.”

He stood to put on his uniform. He is five feet ten, and, like a Rockette, most of his height seems to come from his legs, which he calls “the essence of my game”; they dwarf his torso, which always appears to be pressing forward, as if he were bursting out of a starting gate. His eyes betray frequent shifts in mood--they squint with displeasure, then widen with delight--and, during games, he often hides them behind wraparound sunglasses. He put on his jersey, which was white, with powder-blue sleeves, and pulled his pants above his hips; when he slipped on his cap, only the creases on his forehead and around his mouth confirmed that he was as old as many of his teammates’ fathers. Extending his arms, he said, “Look at me. I ain’t got no injuries. I got no problem with my eyes. My knees are good. The only problem I have is a little pain in my hip, and it ain’t nothin’ a little ice can’t cure.”

Henderson knew that he had only a few months to prove to a scout that he was able to play at the highest level--the major-league season ended in October. He told me that not long after he began playing for the Newark Bears he called Billy Beane, the general manager of the Oakland A’s. Most of Henderson’s greatest achievements in baseball, including his first World Series ring, in 1989, stemmed from his time on the A’s, and he told Beane that he wanted to return to the team more than to any other. “Then I could go out the way I came in,” he said. Beane responded that the A’s, which are currently vying for a spot in the playoffs, had no room for him. Nevertheless, Henderson said, “I ain’t giving up hope. I know if people would just come out to see me play they would realize that Rickey is still Rickey.”

He arrived hours before a game, and would slash at balls as they shot out of a pitching machine at eighty-five miles an hour, while the Surf Dawgs’ adopted theme song blared over the loudspeakers: “Who let the dogs out? Woof! Woof! Woof! Woof!” On some mornings, he could be seen running up and down the bleachers. Jose Canseco, who played with Henderson on the A’s, and who helped to fuel the explosion of performance-enhancing drugs in the major leagues, has said of Henderson, “That’s one of the guys who’s not on steroids!”

“They kept that shit a secret from me,” Henderson said. “I wish they had told me. My God, could you imagine Rickey on ‘roids? Oh, baby, look out!” He laughed in an easygoing way. “Maybe if they weren’t juicing there’d still be a spot on a ball club for me. People always ask me why I still want to play, but I want to know why no one will give me an opportunity. It’s like they put a stamp on me: ‘Hall of Fame. You’re done. That’s it.’ It’s a goddam shame.”

As Henderson was talking to me, one of his teammates, who had tousled hair and looked to be about eighteen, walked over. He was holding a baseball and a pen in his hand. He said to Henderson, “I feel funny asking, but could you sign this?” Henderson smiled and signed the ball. “Thank you, Rickey,” the young man said, holding the ball along the seams, so as not to smudge the ink. Henderson turned back to me, and said, “I’ll tell you the truth. I’d give everything up--every record, the Hall of Fame, all of it--for just one more chance.”

Base stealers are often considered their own breed: reckless, egocentric, sometimes even a touch mad. Ron LeFlore, who stole ninety-seven bases with the Montreal Expos, was a convicted armed robber; Ty Cobb, who was called “psychotic” by his authorized biographer, used to slide with his spikes in the air, in an effort to take out the second baseman; even Lou Brock, who was more gentlemanly, believed that one of his greatest assets was unbridled arrogance. Henderson, by all accounts, was a natural-born thief Lloyd Moseby; a childhood friend of his who played for the Toronto Blue Jays, told Sports Illustrated, “Rickey hasn’t changed since he was a little kid. He could strut before he could walk, and he always rived for the lights.”

Henderson grew up with little outside the game: when he was two, his father disappeared, abandoning the family, and, after his mother moved to California to find work, he and his four brothers remained in Pine Bluff, Arkansas, for several years, in the care of a grand- mother. In 1976, when Henderson was seventeen, the Oakland A’s drafted him in the fourth round and assigned him to one of their minor-league teams, in Boise, Idaho. From the beginning, he was intense, moody, and flamboyant. If he hit what looked like an easy ground out, he sometimes refused to run it out, to the consternation of the manager. But, when he thought the opportunity was ripe, his speed was unparalleled. One night in Fresno, California, in 1977, he stole seven bases, tying a record for a single game. Two years later, in the middle of the season, the Oakland A’s called him up to the majors.

With his new money, Henderson hired a group of detectives to find his father. "I didn't care if he was a bad guy or a good guy," Henderson told me. "I just wanted to know him." The private eyes reported back to his mother, who informed him, "Your father is dead. He died a few years ago in a car accident." In 1980, however, Henderson found an unlikely father figure in Billy Martin, the A's new manager. Martin was a pugnacious drinker who, on at least one occasion, slugged one of his own players. But he and Henderson shared an in-your-face approach to the game. Martin hung on his office wall a poster that said, "There can be no rainbow without a cloud and a storm"--and together they developed a manic style of play, known as Billy Ball, that was as terrifying as it was exhilarating. As Henderson has put it, "Billy was the publisher of Billy Ball, and I was the author."

Because the A's didn't have a lot of power, they couldn't rely on three-run homers and big innings; they had to manufacture runs, to create them out of the slightest opportunities. As the lead-off hitter, Henderson was the catalyst, or, as he likes to say, "the creator of chaos." He had remarkable strength (twice, he finished the season with a higher slugging percentage than Mark McGwire), but his principal role was to be a nuisance, a pest--to "get on base, any damn way I can," and begin wreaking havoc on the defense.

As part of his strategy, he had developed one of the most distinctive and infuriating batting stances ever seen. Each hitter has a strike zone that extends roughly from his chest to his knees. Henderson, by collapsing his shoulders to his knees--by practically doubling over--made his strike zone seem uncommonly small; one sportswriter quipped that it was "the size of Hitler's heart." With so little room for the pitcher to throw a strike, Henderson would frequently eke out a walk. (In 2001, he broke Babe Ruth's record for total walks, and is now second, behind Barry Bonds.) Or he would crush the ball--he is one of only twenty-five players in history with more than three thousand hits. Once he was on base, the chaos began: he would often steal second, then steal third; he stole home four times. In his first full year, he broke Ty Cobb's American League record of ninety-six stolen bases in a season, which had stood since 1915; two seasons later, he blew past Lou Brock's major-league mark of a hundred and eighteen. Thomas Boswell, of the Washington Post, wrote, "Not since Babe Ruth hit fifty-four home runs in 1920--thirty more than anyone else had hit in a season--has one of baseball's fundamental areas of offensive production been in such danger of major redefinition....Now, perhaps for the first time, a player's skill is challenging the basic dimensions of the diamond."

His mere presence on the base paths was a force of psychic disruption. Distracted infielders made errors, and pitchers, finding themselves unable to concentrate, gave up easy hits to subsequent batters. As the former Yankee captain Don Mattingly has said, "Basically, he terrorizes a team." Henderson would score in ways that made his heroics nearly invisible: he would often get a walk, then steal second, then advance to third on a ground ball, and, finally, come home on a routine fly ball to the outfield. In other words, he regularly scored when neither he nor his teammates registered a single hit.

But there was also something out of control about Henderson. A base stealer takes his team's fortunes into his own hands; if he decides to run and gets thrown out, he can devastate a team's chances for a big inning. In 1982, Henderson didn't merely set a season record for steals; he also set one for being caught (forty-two times). The very traits that won him praise--bravado, guile, defiance--also made him despised. During a 1982 game against the Detroit Tigers, when he needed only one more base to tie Brock's record, he singled but had no chance to steal, because there was a slow base runner on second. Violating every norm of the game, Billy Martin ordered the man on second to take such a big lead that he would get picked off. Henderson's path was now clear, and he took off, sure that he was safe at second, but the umpire called him out, allegedly muttering, "You got to earn it."

Baseball has an unspoken etiquette about lopsided games, and Henderson's habit of stealing when his team was already trouncing an opponent was widely seen as unsportsmanlike. In 2001, while Henderson was playing with the San Diego Padres in a game against the Milwaukee Brewers, he took off in the seventh inning, when his team was leading by seven runs. The Brewers' manager, Davey Lopes, who had been one of the most aggressive base stealers of his day was so incensed that he stormed onto the field, yelling that the next time Henderson came up to bat the pitcher was going to "drill" him. The threat was clearly in earnest, and Henderson was removed from the game. "We're old school," Lopes said later.

And it wasn't just the way Henderson ran the bases that irked traditionalists. In 1985, after being traded to the Yankees, he was asked what it would be like to play on the same field that once knew Joe DiMaggio and Mickey Mantle, and he replied, "I don't care about them....It's Rickey time." When he hit a home run, he would stop and watch it go over the fence, then arc ostentatiously around first base, one elbow outstretched like a bird's wing. Instead of simply catching a ball, he would make a show of snatching it out of the air. "I don't appreciate that

hot-dog garbage in my ballpark,” the former Orioles catcher Rick Dempsey, who once had to be restrained by an umpire from attacking Henderson, said.

Henderson earned a reputation for creating tumult off the field as well. He held general managers hostage with his contractual demands. “I’ve got to have my money guaranteed,” he’d say. Or, in one of his more Yogi Berra-like phrases, “All I’m asking for is what I want.” Once, when he couldn’t find his limousine upon leaving a ballpark, he was heard saying, “Rickey don’t like it when Rickey can’t find Rickey’s limo.” In 1989, the A’s signed him to a four-year contract worth twelve million dollars, which made him the highest-paid player in the game; but less than two years later, after several players surpassed that sum, he demanded a new contract. The pitcher Goose Gossage, who played with Henderson on the A’s, once said, “Henderson set a new standard for selfishness. He made Jose Canseco look like a social worker.” By the end of his career in the majors, Henderson was recognized as one of the best players of all time, but, in the view of many players and sportswriters, he was also “greedy,” “egomaniacal,” “Tropical Storm Rickey,” “the classic baseball mercenary,” and “the King of I.” In other words, he was the last player anyone thought would join the Golden Baseball League.

“I can’t be late,” Henderson said. He was at the Los Angeles airport, waiting for a morning flight to Yuma, Arizona, where, for a July game against the Scorpions, the Golden Baseball League was hosting Rickey Henderson Night (The first thousand fans to arrive at the game would receive Rickey Henderson bobble-head dolls.) The league, realizing that Henderson helped give it legitimacy, had offered him various perks to sign on, and, unlike the rest of the players, he didn’t have to endure long bus rides to away games—he flew by commercial airplane. And so, while the team was spending five hours on a bus to Yuma, Henderson picked up his bags and boarded the plane. He was wearing an elegant tan shirt and matching pants, and a gold Rolex studded with diamonds. During his career, he has earned more than forty million dollars in salary alone. He owns dozens of rental properties, as well as a hundred-and-fifty-acre ranch, near Yosemite National Park, where he spent time in the off-season with his wife and their daughters. He also has a Porsche, a Rolls-Royce, a Bentley, a BMW, a Mercedes, a Cadillac, a G.M. truck, a T-bird, and a Ferrari. “I’ve told major-league clubs, ‘Don’t worry about your bank account—I’ll play for free,’” Henderson said. “This ain’t about my portfolio.”

As he waited for the plane to taxi to the runway, he checked his cell phone to see if his agent had called with any word from the majors. “Nothing,” he said. After holding power over general managers for so long, Henderson seemed uncertain what to do now that they held power over him. He had even considered crashing a Colorado Rockies tryout for highschool and college players. He knew that his reputation had probably hurt his chances of being brought onto a team as an elder statesman and bench player. “There’s always that concern: Will Rickey be willing to come off the bench?” Henderson said. “I would. If you let me retire in a major-league uniform, you won’t hear a peep out of me.” Henderson regularly scoured the news reports for injuries and roster changes in the majors, to see if there might be an opening.

“Who’s that new guy they got playing center field for the Yankees?” Henderson asked me.

“Tony Womack,” I said.

“Womack, huh?” he said, then added in frustration, “My God, you mean to tell me I ain’t better than him?”

He placed a call on his cell phone, and began talking over the roar of the engine. The stewardess, who seemed unusually tense, asked him sharply to turn the phone off. He said that he would, but requested that she ask him nicely. Within moments, security officers had boarded the plane to remove him.

“What the hell’s going on?” he asked.

“Is that Rickey Henderson?” a passenger asked.

“Look how cut he is,” another said. “I hear he never lifts weights—he only does pushups and situps.”

“You’ll have to come with us,” an officer told Henderson.

I stood up to get off with Henderson, and the officer asked who I was.

“That’s my biographer and lawyer,” Henderson said.

The passengers began to shout, “You can’t take Rickey!” But the stewardess wouldn’t relent, although Henderson said that if he had done something to offend her he was happy to apologize. The plane took off without us. “See, man?” Henderson said to me. “I cause controversy even when I don’t do nothin’. That’s the way it’s always been.”

The airline, seemingly embarrassed by his removal, tried to find us another flight, but the next one to Yuma didn’t leave until the evening. “I gotta make my game,” Henderson said. “It’s Rickey Henderson Night.” Eventually, the airline found us a flight to Imperial, California, which was about an hour’s drive from Yuma; from there, the

airline said, it would provide a car to take us to the stadium. When we arrived at the Imperial airport, a middle-aged man standing in the baggage-claim area said, "Rickey, what brings you to Imperial?"

"Got a game tonight in Yuma."

"In Yuma?"

"Playing in a new independent league over there."

"You trying to make it back to the show?"

"That's the plan."

"Well, I sure wish they'd give you a shot. They never treat us old guys well."

We drove in a van across the desert to Yuma, which is known primarily for a prison that once housed outlaws from the Wild West. When we reached Desert Sun Stadium, Henderson seemed taken aback--it was little more than a field with bleachers and a water tank looming over it. "It ain't Yankee Stadium, is it?" Henderson said.

The temperature was a hundred and nine degrees, and it was hard to breathe. Henderson signed autographs and posed for photographs with fans--"I'm, like, the Babe Ruth of the independent leagues," he said--and then went into the clubhouse to suit up. The bus for the rest of the team had already arrived, and the players were lounging in their underwear; a few were chewing sunflower seeds and discussing a rumor that a scout from a major-league organization had appeared at a recent game.

By now, Henderson knew most of his teammates' stories. There was Nick Guerra, a former college star who worked a construction job in the mornings to support his family. There was Scott Goodman, a slightly pear-shaped power hitter, who once hit eighteen home runs for a minor-league team affiliated with the Florida Marlins but was released anyway. And there was Adam Johnson, perhaps the most promising player on the team, a twenty-six-year-old starting pitcher who had lost only one game all season. The manager, Terry Kennedy, who had played fourteen years in the major leagues as a catcher, and whose father had played in the majors as well, told me, "I sometimes call this the Discovery League. Everybody here is trying to discover something about themselves--whether they should continue pursuing their dream or whether it's time to finally let it go."

Henderson and Goodman went out to the batting cage together. Goodman, who was among the league leaders in home runs and R.B.I.s, had been struggling with his swing in recent games. "How you feeling?" Henderson asked him.

"Last night, I wasn't getting my bat out right."

"I don't mean last night. I'm not worried about last night. How do you feel now?"

"I don't know," Goodman said. "It's like I'm not getting my weight behind anything." He went into the cage and swung at several pitches.

"See your foot?" Henderson said. "You're stepping too far in, instead of toward the pitcher."

Goodman inspected the divot in the dirt where his front foot had landed. "You're right," he said. "I never noticed."

Kennedy told me that he had initially worried how Henderson would fit in with the team, especially considering his perks. "I was never into guys who chirp," he said. But, to his surprise, Henderson had gone out of his way to mentor other players. "I don't want to go too deep into his head," Kennedy said. "But something's clearly going on in there. I think maybe he's trying to show clubs that he's willing to be a different player."

After a while, Goodman and Henderson returned to the clubhouse. They put on their road uniforms, which were gray and navy blue, and walked onto the field, their cleats leaving marks in the sticky grass. Despite the heat, more than four thousand people had come out for Rickey Henderson Night--the biggest crowd in Yuma since the opening night of the season. As Henderson took his position in center field, a yellow Volkswagen Beetle, with a pair of rodent-like ears attached to its roof and a curly tail sticking out of its trunk, circled the grass. "It's time to exterminate the competition," the stadium announcer said. "Truly Nolen Pest Control--We get the bugs out for you." After the first inning, Henderson sat on the bench, his uniform already soaked with sweat, while cheerleaders danced on the dugout roof over his head. The announcer said, "See if you can answer tonight's trivia question! The question is: What year was Rickey Henderson originally drafted by the Oakland A's?"

"Nineteen seventy-six," one of Henderson's teammates said. "I wasn't even born then," another said.

At one point, with Henderson playing center field, a shot was hit over his head and he began to run, unleashing at least a memory of his speed. He looked back over his shoulder, trying to bring the ball into focus, and made a nice catch. "Thataway, Rickey!" his teammates yelled when he came back to the dugout. Even though Henderson played well, with two singles and a walk, the Surf Dawgs lost, 5-0. His wife, who had come to see him play that

weekend with two of their daughters, told the team's general manager, "Why won't he just quit and come home?" As he left the field, fireworks began to explode in the sky above him, the finale of Rickey Henderson Night.

One afternoon before a home game, Kennedy approached Henderson at the ballpark and asked if he would teach the other players the art of stealing. Kennedy knew that, in recent years, base stealing had been all but forgotten in the major leagues. Team owners, convinced that home runs brought people to the stadium, had built smaller and smaller ballparks; at the same time, players made their muscles bigger and bigger with steroids. Since 1982, when Henderson broke the single-season record for steals, home-run totals had risen by sixty-one per cent, while the number of stolen bases had fallen nearly twenty per cent. But Kennedy knew how devastating stealing could be: he had been with the San Francisco Giants in the 1989 World Series, when Henderson and the A's swept the Giants in four games and Henderson set a post-season record, with eleven stolen bases.

Henderson agreed to give a demonstration, and there was a buzz as Goodman, Johnson, and the other players gathered around first base. Henderson stepped off the bag, spread his legs, and bent forward, wiggling his fingers. "The most important thing to being a good base stealer is you got to be fearless," he said. "You know they're all coming for you; everyone in the stadium knows they're coming for you. And you got to say to yourself, 'I don't give a dang. I'm gone.'" He said that every pitcher has the equivalent of a poker player's "tell," something that tips the runner off when he's going to throw home. Before a runner gets on base, he needs to identify that tell, so he can take advantage of it. "Sometimes a pitcher lifts a heel, or wiggles a shoulder, or cocks an elbow, or lifts his cap," Henderson said, indicating each giveaway with a crisp gesture.

Once you were on base, Henderson said, the next step was taking a lead. Most players, he explained, mistakenly assume that you need a big lead. "That's one of Rickey's theories: Rickey takes only three steps from the bag," he said. "If you're taking a big lead, you're going to be all tense out there, Then everyone knows you're going. Just like you read the pitcher, the pitcher and' catcher have read you."

He spread his legs again and pretended to stare at the pitcher. "O.K., you've taken your lead; now you're ready to find that one part of the pitcher's body that you already know tells you he's throwing home, The second you see the sign, then, boom, you're gone." He lifted his knees and dashed toward second base. After he stopped, he said, "I'll tell you another of Rickey's theories." Nearly all base stealers, he explained, begin their run by crossing their left foot in front of their right, as they turn their bodies toward second. That was also a mistake. "If you cross over, it forces you to stand straight up to get into your stride, he said. "That's the worst thing you can do as a runner. You want to start out low and explode."

As Henderson was conducting his demonstration, members of the opposing team arrived and began to look on. He said that the final touch was the slide. Before Henderson, the great base stealers typically went feet first. Henderson decided that it would be faster--not to mention more daring and stylish--to go in head first, the way Pete Rose, who was never a major base stealer, occasionally did. Yet each time Henderson tried the head-first slide he would bounce violently, brutally pounding his body. Then, one day, while he was flying to a game, he noticed that the pilot landed the plane in turbulence without a single bump. Henderson recalled, "I asked the pilot, I said, 'How the hell did you do that?' He said the key is coming in low to the ground, rather than dropping suddenly. I was, like, 'Dang. That's it!'" After that, Henderson said, he lowered his body gradually to the ground, like an airplane.

Henderson concluded by saying that if the base runner studied the pitcher, made a good jump, and slid well, he should beat the throw nearly every time. And, if for some reason he was caught, the moment he got back on base he should try to steal again. As Henderson put it to me, "To steal a base, you need to think you're invincible."

"Look at your head, the Surf Dawgs' hitting instructor said to Henderson one July afternoon. "You're dropping it down."

"I know it," Henderson said, stepping back in the batting cage. He took several more swings, but nothing seemed to be going right. "Come on, Rickey, you're better than this!" he yelled. In July, his batting average had plunged from .311 to .247--one of the lowest on the team. (Recently, it climbed to .270.) In May, he hit only one home run; he had none in June. "He still sees the ball well," Kennedy, who was leaning against the cage, said of Henderson. "But he doesn't have the bat speed to get around."

After a dismal series against the Samurai Bears, an all-Japanese squad that had the worst record in the league, Henderson began staring at the ground in the outfield. Kennedy turned to his coaches and said, "I've think we've lost him." Kennedy, believing that Henderson was ready to quit, later called him into his office. "I understand if you're through," Kennedy said.

"No, man, it's not that. It's just my damn hitting. I can't get it straight."

As the weeks wore on, it became clearer that the defiant mind-set that had made him a great base stealer had, in many ways, trapped him in the Golden Baseball League. He was forever convinced that he could do the impossible. "When I went to play with the Newark Bears, I was sure I would be there for only a few weeks--that a major-league team would call me," he said. "But one week became two weeks, and now it's two years and I'm still waiting for that call."

Trying to improve his average, he started to experiment with his trademark crouch; he stood straighter at the plate, until he was an almost unrecognizable figure. "I remember at the end of my career I began to doubt my ability," Kennedy said. "I knew what I wanted to do, but my body wouldn't let me do it. And I called my father and said, 'Dad, did you ever start to think you weren't good enough to play this game?' And he said, 'I did, and once you do you can never get it back.'"

During the game against the Scorpions in late July, after Henderson had singled and was on first, he got into his three-step lead. I had been travelling with the team periodically throughout the season, waiting to see him steal. The crowd implored him to run, and several times the pitcher threw to first to keep him close. "Here he goes!" a fan yelled. "Watch out!" But, when the pitcher went into his motion, Henderson didn't move. He stood there, frozen. "What's wrong, Rickey?" another fan yelled. "Can't you steal anymore?" On the next pitch, Henderson took his lead again and wiggled his fingers. The pitcher seemed to dip his shoulder when he was about to throw home his tell--but Henderson didn't break. After several more pitches, the batter hit a ground ball to short and Henderson was easily thrown out at second. As Henderson returned to the dug-out, he shouted, "Goddam cocksucking sun was in my eyes. I couldn't see a goddam motherfucking bullshit thing." He sat in the dugout with his head bowed, and for the first time since I had seen him play he didn't say a word.

Two weeks later, in the middle of August, as the Surf Dawgs' season was nearing its end, word spread in the clubhouse that the Oakland A's had just phoned about a player. Kennedy came out and told the team the good news: a Surf Dawg was being called up to Oakland's AAA farm team. It was Adam Johnson, the pitcher. Afterward, Henderson told me, "I'm happy to see one of the guys get out of the league, to get a chance to move on." He seemed genuinely glad for him and refused to mention his own circumstances. On another night on the field, however, he pointed to the Surf Dawg logo on his jersey and said, "I never thought I might end my career in this uniform." I asked if he would retire at the end of the season. "I don't know if I can keep going," he said. "I'm tired, you know." As he picked up his glove, he stared at the field for a moment. Then he said, "I just don't know if Rickey can stop."